

89 Ellipsis

Some words can be left out of a sentence to avoid repetition, or when the meaning can be understood without them. This is called ellipsis.

See also:

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89.1 ELLIPSIS AFTER CONJUNCTIONS

When two phrases are joined by “and,” “but,” or “or” it is common to leave out repeated words of various kinds.

He bought tickets, **but** [he] didn't go.

Often a repeated subject is dropped after “and,” “but,” or “or.”



She loved the original **and** [she loved] the sequel.

If the meaning remains clear, a repeated subject and verb can be dropped.



I'm happy to go out **or** [I'm happy to] stay home.

If the meaning is clear, words that have already been mentioned and do not require repetition can be omitted.



TIP

Ellipsis is not normally possible after conjunctions other than “and,” “but,” and “or.”

FURTHER EXAMPLES

She said she'd call, **but** she didn't [call].



I hope my camera works, **but** I don't think it will [work].



You can watch the documentary **or** [you can watch] the cartoon.



Please may I have a knife **and** [a] fork?



I'd love to be a boxer, **but** I'm not strong enough [to be a boxer].



I can't decide if I want a burger **or** [I want] a hotdog.

